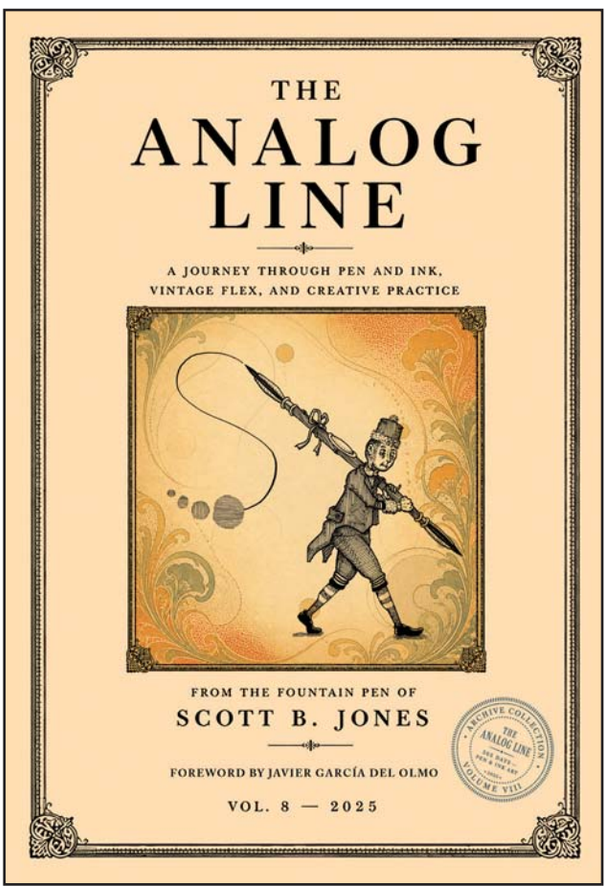
The Surreal World of Scott B. Jones

BY BARRY GABAY

Producing a book's worth of pen and ink illustrations each year, this contemporary artist continues the legacy of the golden age of cartooning.





Above—pen-and-ink artist Scott B. Jones surrounded by the surreal, whimsical illustrations he creates on a daily basis.
Right—Jones's most recent collection of his daily pen-and-ink illustrations, *The Analog Line.*

The art of Scott B. Jones seems to appear everywhere: in books, on social media, on posters, and even in the classroom. More than an artist huddled in his studio producing remarkable pen and ink drawings, Scott is a publicist for antique writing instruments, heralding the virtues of flex nibs and various filling systems to anyone eager to learn. His pen show seminars, entitled "The Analog Line," offer a "journey through pen and ink, vintage flex, and creative practice." The 90-minute course covers the 1870s through the 1960s and features major and obscure brands, various nibs, and filling systems. For many participants, it's the first time they have held and used a 120-year-old fountain pen. Scott speaks through his art and with his pen, but also with the eloquence and enthusiasm of a dedicated curator of fountain pen history.

Scott's earliest memories are of drawing. He was an only child, and in the absence of siblings, he often entertained himself. He remembers drawing from a very young age, not just at home but everywhere. When his parents took him to restaurants, he turned over the paper placemats and began drawing with a supply of pencils and crayons. Scott taught himself to draw on his lap while in a formal setting, listening to music in a concert hall. During these outings, there was double stimulation: auditory, which was provided by the symphony program, and visual, which he created himself.

Scott remembers those times as "the fertile ground of making marks on paper." Even then, at such a young age, he drew sketches—outlines of images that he would later shade or leave as simple line drawings. He loved the border, the edge, the surrounding lines.



From top left—covers of Volumes 1 through 7 of Jones's collections of daily illustrations, with both back and front covers of Volume 5, *Flippity Flappity Floop*, at above left.

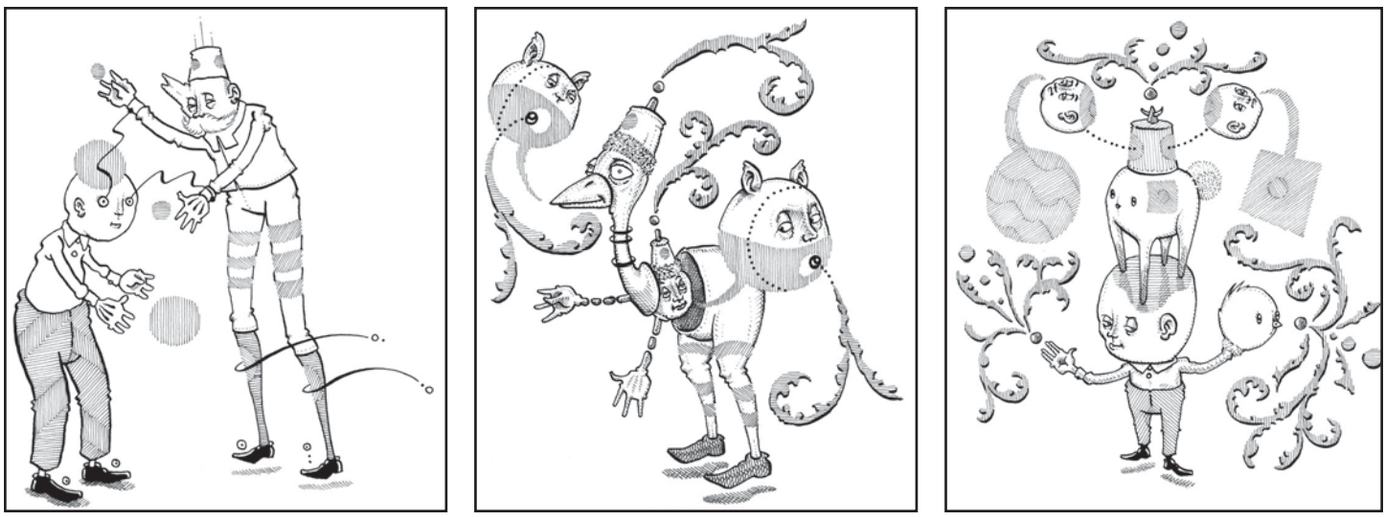
That tendency still characterizes his mature and much-respected work. His line drawings allow the viewer to fill in spaces. The artwork is complete in and of itself, but there is always more to see, more the audience brings to this experience. One basic and important aspect of Scott's personality and development hasn't changed over the years: he still feels comfortable drawing wherever he happens to be.

Scott attended the School of Visual Arts in New York City, New York, beginning as an illustration major. Later, he switched to graphic design. While he appreciated the quickness and variety of manipulation the discipline allowed, "I hated sitting behind a computer," he remembers. He transitioned to working in film. Each day, returning from work, he sat down to draw. It relaxed him and allowed him a single focus: one blank page.

Scott began a blog of drawings in 2010 that contained photos of his drawings on paper. He committed himself to at least one drawing a day beginning on January 1, 2012. After a year, he knew he would continue; it had become a part of his daily ritual. He describes it as "natural to me. It's a part of my life. I think of drawing like brushing my teeth, which is important to health. A daily ritual of pen-and-ink drawing is mental floss for me."

By 2014, he stopped posting his daily drawings on the blog. At that point, he concentrated on planning and producing books of drawings. To date, he has published eight of them.

Scott calls artistic line work from the Arts and Crafts Movement a major influence. This late 19th century artistic movement involved visual art, furniture, and textiles. Simplicity and purity were paramount; decorative elements were secondary to the central object. This could be a definition of Scott's work. The image itself is most important. The viewer understands immediately where to focus, what to observe and study.

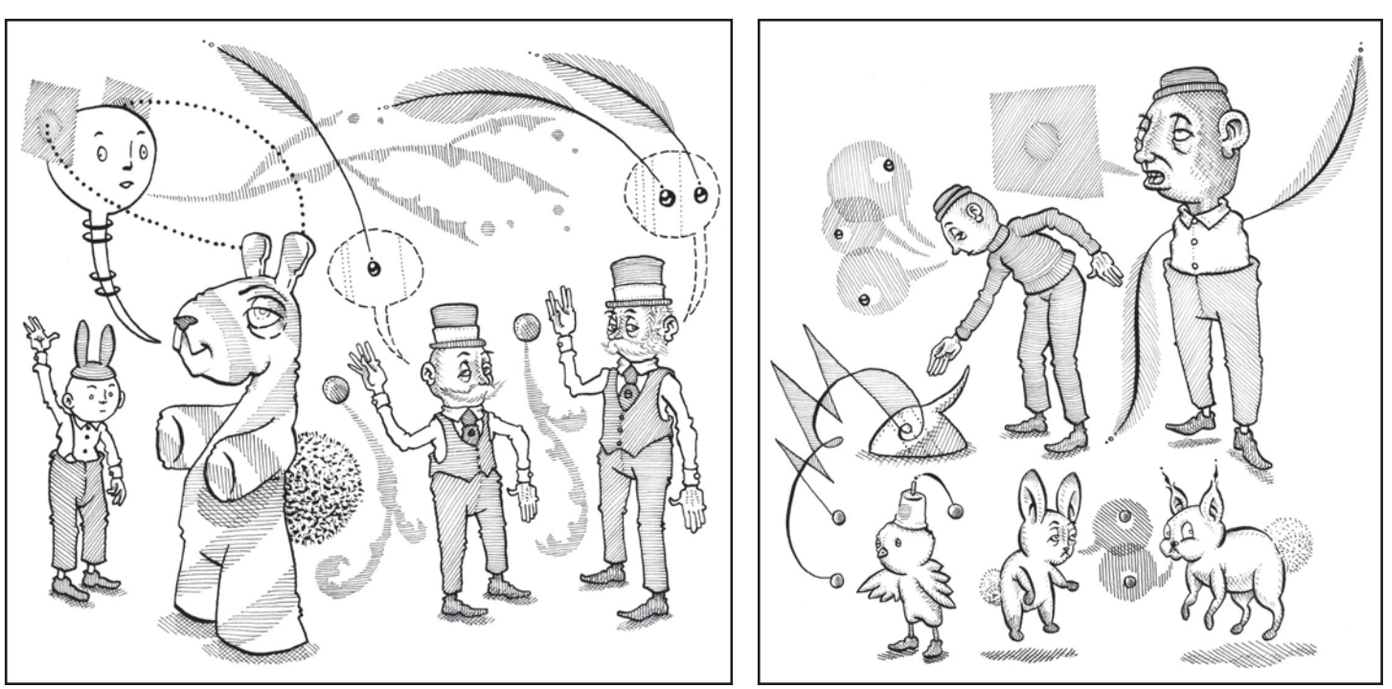


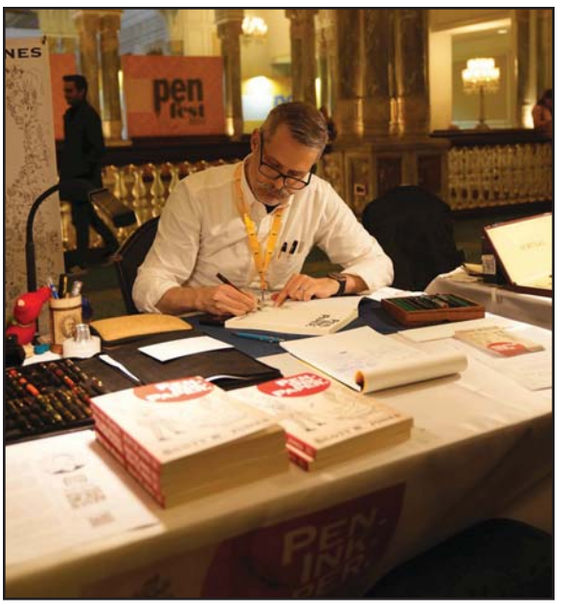
Above—daily illustrations from June 21 through 23, 2026, showcase Jones's skill in fine line drawing and his vintage illustrative style, which harkens to both the golden age of illustration and the fine art Surrealist movement.
Bottom—illustrations from July 7 and 8, 2026, showcase Jones's mastery of negative space to ensure that each character is at once individuated and connected to the greater scene.

Scott glows when he mentions another important influence on his aesthetic and his work, the golden age of illustration, which is characterized by early newspaper and magazine illustrations in 1820s Paris, France, and 1840s London, England. The trend arrived in the United States by the 1850s.

With the beginnings of mechanical printing in the Industrial Age and the rise of public education, large segments of populations were exposed to newspapers and magazines. The British illustrated humor magazine *Punch* is perhaps the best-known example from this era. In the United States, Thomas Nast, drawing for *Harper's Weekly*, created our popular image of Santa Claus and the political party symbols of Elephant and Donkey. Most newspapers had an illustrated comics page or section. Scott mentions Ernie Bushmiller, creator of *Fritzi Ritz* and *Nancy*, among his favorite artists. He cites *Mad* Magazine as the last great illustrated magazine.

Scott illustrates entirely with fountain pens. He received his first fountain pen while still a student in art school. He was an assistant to several artists, including Fred Mitchell, who gave him an inexpensive disposable fountain pen to use. Today, Scott returns the generosity by giving disposable fountain pens to children at pen shows.







Left—Jones at the 2024 Istanbul, Türkiye, PenFest. Photo courtesy of Alihan Kutlu.
Above—Jones teaching at the 2026 Atlanta Pen Show.

Later, he met the artist Jim Woodring, who did a drawing for him with a fountain pen. Scott knew at that point he wanted a good fountain pen. A nagging question was how to achieve the flexibility of a dip pen, which he enjoyed using, with a fountain pen. The answer, of course, is to write or draw with very old vintage pens.

Because he lived in New York City, Scott knew about Fountain Pen Hospital. He visited the store, searched in the vintage department, and tested several old pens. He bought a Waterman 54 Black Hard Rubber from the 1920s with a very flexible nib. That day, Scott discovered the ideal tool for his drawings. Soon, he was test-driving other vintage pens from the late 19th and early 20th centuries. Notable among them were Paul Wirt, Mabie Todd and Bard, more Watermans, and a Montblanc 132 from the 1930s—the more flex the better.

While all of Scott's vintage pens have nibs that flex, he smiles when he says that his Montblanc 132 flexes from extra-fine to broad with little pressure. Among his modern pens is a TWSBI with a broad nib, which gives a wide line in any direction. His inks of choice are De Artramentis waterproof black and Waterman black, which he says are safe with vintage pens.

In 2010, Scott met Myk Daigle (@mad_mercantile), a widely respected vintage pen restorer. Scott bought some early 20th century fountain pens from him, and their friendship has evolved. Today, they can be found at approximately 10 pen shows annually sitting side by side, Scott's table filled with his drawings and books, Myk's with the vintage flex-nib fountain pens that allow Scott's art to emerge. They represent the mechanical and the artistic joined seamlessly in friendship—two halves of a technical and aesthetic whole.

Scott says of Myk, "He approaches pens from a structural and an artistic standpoint. He is able to convey what the tool does. He's a tinkerer. He brings old pens back to life."

Scott himself also buys, sells, and restores vintage fountain pens.

In another example of Scott's connection to the fountain pen community, world-renowned American Master Penman Michael Sull wrote the introduction to Scott's 2024 book *Vintage Fountain Pen Therapy*. He describes Scott's work as a "door of fantasy into [a] magical world" and Scott as possessing the "singular ability to capture the wonder, playful expression, humor, and whimsy that too many of us seem to have lost since childhood." He calls Scott "a poet with his pen."

"The pendulum is back on the analog side," Scott says of his popularity among pen-and-ink enthusiasts, but he notes, "I would do this even if there were no audience, no books. It's what I care about. It's a personal way to approach creativity."

For Scott, his fulfillment comes from one dark mark against the stark whiteness of a page. That's how he begins each drawing: two simple elements—black lines on a white background. For me, Scott's work is a dreamy catalog of characters and situations. The simple lines of ink on paper possess the ability to transport us to a delightful and engaging world far removed from our day-to-day reality.

Visit www.scottjonesny.com or scan the QR code at right. Visit his blog, scottjonesny.blogspot.com.

See more daily sketches from Scott B. Jones on page 104 in this issue.

Barry Gabay is a PW *Contributing Editor.*

The Daily Sketches of Scott B. Jones

Scott B. Jones creates his art with vintage fountain pens and dip pens, so it's not surprising that pen-centric images often populate his daily sketches. Here are some of our favorite compositions from *The Analog Line*, Jones's collection of sketches from the 2025 calendar year.

Follow Jones on Instagram, @scottjonesny, to see his current sketches, and visit www.scottjonesny.com to order *The Analog Line* along with his preceding seven volumes of daily sketches.



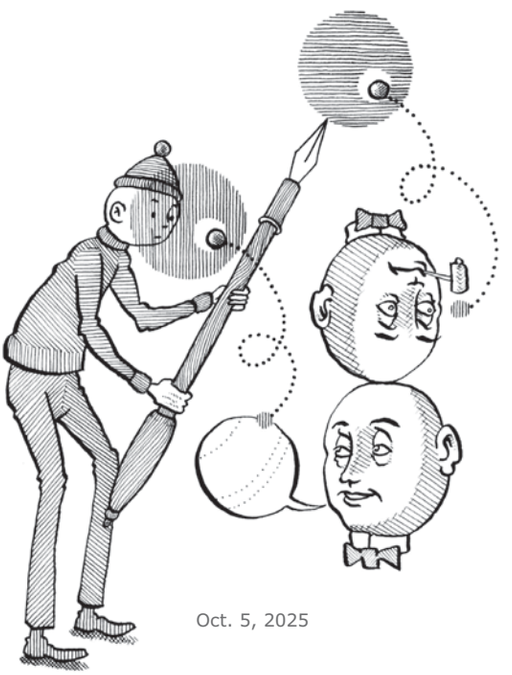
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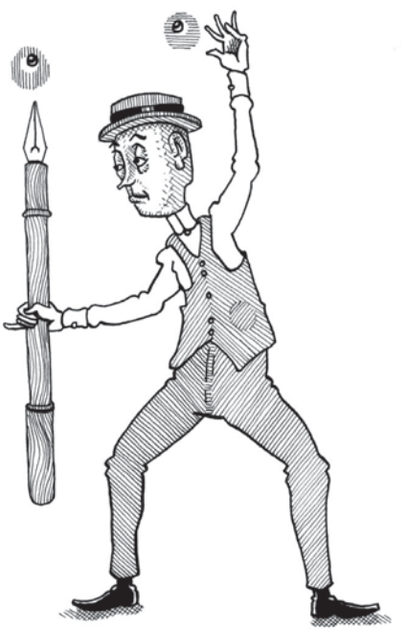
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